EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Are There Misvot in Olam HaBa?

Given Monday 10 November 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:9-11

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Olam HaBa, The World to Come), Chapters 9, 10 and 11 (the end of the essay)

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 10 November 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Saadia's Picture So Far

"We are close to finishing. We may well finish tonight essay 9." Three chapters remained, and the Rabbi got through all three.

The first part of the essay brought sources for Olam HaBa from logic, Torah and tradition. Then Saadia began his questions on its nature:

Questions	Saadia's answer
1 and 2: reward and punishment	Intense **light** for the righteous, **fire** for the wicked
3: place	A **new world**, newly created
4: time	**No time**, apart from one point to come tonight, since time is a construct of this world, for relationships and rental contracts
5 and 6: eternity	Reward and punishment are both **perpetual**
7 and 8: levels	Not all equal: the intensity of the light matches one's mitzvot, and the intensity of the punishment one's wickedness, as some are merely imprisoned and some are imprisoned and tortured

Tonight: Who deserves Gehinnom? Do people in Olam HaBa see each other? Are there mitzvot in Olam HaBa, and if so, what is their reward?

Chapter 9, Question 9: Who Deserves Gehinnom?

For Saadia, punishment in Olam HaBa is the same as Gehinnom: the intense fire, which he seems to understand very physically. Who receives it perpetually?

הכופרים והמשתפים ובעלי עבירות החמורות אשר לא עשו תשובה

The deniers, those who associate others with God, and those guilty of the grave sins who did not repent.

1. **Deniers and idolaters.** Of them the pasuk says:

ויצאו וראו בפגרי האנשים הפשעים בי (Yeshayahu 66:24)

They will go out and see the corpses of the people who rebelled against Me.

"Rebelled against Me" means either denying God or worshipping another deity besides Him.

1. **Those guilty of grave sins**: sins for which the Torah prescribes **karet** or **a death penalty of the beit din**, such as murder, adultery or eating on Yom Kippur. Whoever is cut off from this world is also cut off from the righteous in the next, because he did not repent. And if he was **not** cut off in this world but lived out a long life and still did not repent, **his punishment is harsher**, because he was given more time and still did not do teshuvah.

Anyone else, whose sins are lighter, can be atoned for and will not go to Gehinnom.

The clear implication, "which everyone agrees to," is that teshuvah atones for even the gravest sin. Gehinnom is for those who did not do teshuvah.

What is karet for Saadia?

"It's the first time he's talked about karet explicitly." The Rabbi set out three views:

- **The Rambam:** karet has nothing to do with this life. It means having **no portion in Olam HaBa**: you die and have no existence after death.
- **Tosafot**, in one of the first Tosafot in Yevamot: karet is **an early death**, at fifty or sixty (there are different opinions). A very physical understanding.
- **Saadia:** "a kind of combination." Someone who commits a karet sin is likely to die early, but not necessarily. Either way, karet in the next world means **intense punishment in Olam HaBa**. "For Saadia, Olam HaBa, Gehinnom, karet, these are all synonymous terms for people who suffer in the world to come."

What about lesser sins?

If I spoke lashon hara or ate non-kosher food, why do I not go to Gehinnom? Saadia answers: these are light, and the fact that a person has only these means **he guarded himself from the grave ones**. He must have kept the other mitzvot: he did not deny, he believed, he did not worship idols, did not murder, did not commit adultery, did not steal, and acted with justice and righteousness. Sins that are only negative prohibitions without karet or a death penalty can be atoned.

But they still need atonement. Saadia, referring back to Essay 5: whoever's deeds are mostly merits, with a few such sins against them, **is repaid for those sins in this world and leaves it clean**.

Two boxes, again

"This is precisely the point I discussed last week. It's very black and white."

- **The rasha**, with the grave sins (or more sins than mitzvot): perpetual Gehinnom, its intensity depending on how many sins, "either am I going to be just red hot, or am I going to be singed like the back of a pot." His mitzvot are rewarded in this world.

- **The tzaddik**, without grave sins, or who did teshuvah for them: Gan Eden, its level depending on his mitzvot, "some will be like the sun itself, some only rays of the sun." His sins are atoned through suffering in this world.
- **The beinoni**, exactly fifty-fifty, is pushed over to tzaddik.

The Rabbi added that, though Saadia does not mention it, it seems possible in rare cases for someone with no grave sins to have so many minor sins that they outweigh his mitzvot. "It's very difficult to accept this kind of scheme, but that's the way Saadia believes."

Richard's question

Does teshuvah also work for karet sins? **Teshuvah applies to every sin**, including karet and the death penalties of the beit din. "What do we say on Yom Kippur over and over and over again?"

על חטא שחטאנו לפניך בכרת... על חטא שחטאנו לפניך בארבע מיתות בית דין: סקילה, שרפה, הרג וחנק

"Of course you have to go through the principles of teshuvah, like we've learned in the past, and make sure you do it properly. But in principle, there's nothing which cannot be atoned with teshuvah."

Chapter 9, Question 10: Do People See Each Other?

הצדיקים והרשעים רואים קצתם את קצתם

The righteous and the wicked see one another.

The righteous see the wicked

Again from **ויצאו וראו בפגרי האנשים הפשעים בי**. The Rabbi noted that others read this pasuk as referring to the time of techiyat hametim: the righteous rise and see the dead who do not rise. Saadia reads it as Olam HaBa. When the righteous see the suffering of the wicked, they will say: **praised be He who saved us from these sufferings**, and they will rejoice in their own lot.

"I find this difficult. It's almost a kind of 'I'm not like you, I'm much higher than you.'" It recalls being honoured through another's disgrace, **מתכבד בקלון חברו**.

The wicked see the righteous

פחדו בציון חטאים אחזה רעדה חנפים (Yeshayahu 33:14)

Sinners in Zion are afraid; trembling has seized the hypocrites.

They will be astonished that the righteous pass through the burning fire and are not hurt: "We are burnt by this fire, we are in constant pain. And you, the tzaddikim, seem to be having light from the fire, but you don't get burnt." And they will groan at the reward they lost. Saadia's analogy: people invited to a feast, while others are summoned only to watch them eat, and sigh as they watch.

הנה עבדי יאכלו ואתם תרעבו (Yeshayahu 65:13)

Behold, My servants will eat, and you will be hungry.

The source: Vayikra Rabbah

Saadia does not cite it, but his wording clearly comes from a Midrash in **Vayikra Rabbah** on the last pasuk of Tehillim 12, which the Rabbi said we recite on Shemini Atzeret:

סביב רשעים יתהלכון (Tehillim 12:9)

The wicked walk all around.

- The first opinion: **around the wicked the righteous walk**. When the righteous leave Gan Eden and see the wicked judged in Gehinnom, **נפשם שמחה עליהם**, and they praise HaKadosh Baruch Hu for the sufferings He brought on them in this world. The Rabbi suggested this does not mean they are happy that the wicked suffer, but that they are happy with their own lot: what they suffered in this world was worth it for the next.
- **Rabbi Chanina** says the reverse: **around the righteous the wicked walk**. When the wicked come up from Gehinnom and see the righteous sitting at peace in Gan Eden, their souls are pained. "Why did I not get this reward?"

So Saadia has a source. There are hints in the Gemara as well: **כל אחד ואחד נכוה מחופתו של חבירו**, each person in Olam HaBa is "burnt" by the canopy of the one greater than him.

But for the **Rambam**, the Rabbi said, such a concept is not possible: there is no physicality, so no seeing each other. The Rambam would say not every Midrash is to be taken literally; some must be interpreted differently, and not every opinion is accepted. The Tuesday shiur the next night, on what the Rabbi called "one of the most important paragraphs" in the Rambam on the afterlife, would show why.

Do the righteous see each other?

Saadia continues: among the righteous, **those whose levels are close will meet**, and those whose levels are far apart will not. Someone on the top rung will not see someone on the bottom rung of Gan Eden. "Where did he get this from? I don't know."

And the wicked? Saadia offers a guess, **ועלה בדעתי**: even those close in level **do not meet**, perhaps because they are so occupied with their own pain that they cannot pay attention to anyone else. "You live in your own suffering."

Chapter 10: Is There Avodat Hashem in Olam HaBa?

"Now we come to something even more astonishing." Ask the average person what Olam HaBa is, and they will say it is where you reap the consequences of your actions. Are there further mitzvot there? "I imagine 99.9% of people will tell you, of course not," because **היום לעשותם ומחר לקבל שכרם**: today to do them, tomorrow to receive their reward. "I've never seen it before, and I don't know anyone else who says this."

Saadia: yes

Is there service of Hashem in Olam HaBa? **"I say yes."**

1. **Logic.** It is not possible that a rational being would be left without command and service. If service were unnecessary in the next world, Hashem would have made it unnecessary in this one too. Since He made us serve Him here, we must serve Him there.
2. **What the service is.** There remains a duty **to believe in His divinity**, and not to attribute to Him what angers Him or describe Him with unworthy qualities. "This is the way of complete reason, and it is impossible otherwise."
3. **Scripture.** There is another, regular service. Hashem will designate a place to which people come from where they live (remember, Olam HaBa for Saadia is a physical world) at set intervals, **like Shabbat**

and Rosh Chodesh for us now. They will serve there as commanded and return home without further service:

והיה מדי חדש בחדשו ומדי שבת בשבתו יבוא כל בשר להשתחות לפני אמר ה' (Yeshayahu 66:23)

From new moon to new moon and from Shabbat to Shabbat, all flesh will come to bow before Me, says Hashem.

And when they have finished, **ויצאו וראו בפגרי האנשים הפשעים בי**: they go out and see the wicked.

Most other Rishonim read this pasuk as referring to the days of Mashiach and techiyat hametim, when the Beit HaMikdash is rebuilt and sacrifices offered. Saadia reads it as Olam HaBa. And since he said earlier there is no time in Olam HaBa, how will people know when to serve? "I don't know. Obviously they'll be told." That is why he says it will be **like** Shabbat and Rosh Chodesh. This is the "one point" of time he had mentioned in Chapter 6.

1. **The Gemara.** The righteous do not stand idle in the next world any more than in this one:

תלמידי חכמים אין להם מנוחה לא בעולם הזה ולא בעולם הבא, שנאמר ילכו מחיל אל חיל יראה אל אלהים בציון (Berachot 64a)

Torah scholars have no rest, neither in this world nor in the next, as it says: they go from strength to strength, appearing before God in Zion.

The wicked do not serve

If the righteous serve, might the wicked also serve and so rectify themselves? No. The wicked are not commanded to serve, **because of their suffering**: part of their punishment is that they have no more chance. And service would take them out of their perpetual punishment, which would be harsher than the law allows, since we have said the punishment is perpetual.

"Mitzvot Are Void in the Future"

"Saadia is a complete outlier here." The pasuk can easily be refuted, since it is likely about the time of techiyat hametim and the Beit HaMikdash. And there are Gemarot that say the exact opposite.

Shabbat 151b. Even for **David HaMelech**, who died on Shabbat, one may not desecrate Shabbat once he has died. Why? **כיון שמת אדם בטל מן המצוות**: once a person dies, he is free of the mitzvot. That is why we break Shabbat to save a life: as the Gemara in Yoma says,

חלל עליו שבת אחת כדי שישמור שבתות הרבה (Yoma 85b)

Desecrate one Shabbat for him so that he may keep many Shabbatot.

We save a life so that the person can do more mitzvot. A dead person cannot, so we do not break Shabbat for him. And Rabbi Yochanan on **במתים חפשי** (Tehillim 88:6), "free among the dead": "Dead people have a holiday?" No: **once a person dies he becomes free of the mitzvot**.

Niddah 61b. A garment with **sha'atnez** may not be sold to a non-Jew or made into a saddle for a donkey, but it **may be made into shrouds for the dead**. Rav Yosef says: **זאת אומרת מצוות בטלות לעתיד לבא**, this teaches that mitzvot are void in the future. "I know people nowadays wouldn't like to do that. But this is halachah. Halachah is you can get buried with sha'atnez."

The Rabbi's resolution

"The only answer I can think of": look again at Saadia's language. He speaks of **service** and **duty**: to believe in God, not to speak badly of Him, and the periodic bowing and offerings. "I think you have to say we have no other choice but to say that even according to Saadia there are no mitzvot in the world to come," no halachot, no sha'atnez, no Shabbat, no building a sukkah or eating matzah. Those belong to this world, as the Gemarot say. **There are no mitzvot, but there is avodah**, because, Saadia says, serving Hashem is something one must do for eternity.

"This is my own interpretation. I don't know if this is correct or not, but I found it so difficult to square this with the most basic Gemarot, which everyone agrees to." If a dead person had mitzvot, why could I not break Shabbat for him?

"But even that, nobody agrees to him. We're taught from a young age, and rightly so, that the time to do mitzvot, the time to serve Hashem, is in this world. The next world is consequences." For the Rambam it does not begin: Olam HaBa is **נהנים מזיו השכינה**.

How others read "no rest in the next world"

The Rabbi's own understanding has always been that the Gemara means **continuous elevation**. The **Ramchal** says explicitly that one rises higher and higher in Olam HaBa, according to one's deeds. The Ramban would say something similar: it takes time to shed one's physical identity, so one keeps growing.

The Ben Ish Chai: the mitzvot cease at death, "for a person becomes free of the mitzvot after death and his deeds are complete; but from the study of Torah he is not free, for even after death the soul engages in Torah above." That is far from Saadia. It is not service with choice, but continuous development of the intellect, "and the Rambam would agree with that."

The Maharsha asks why the Gemara says **talmidei chachamim** and not tzaddikim. Because it is about the **intellect**: there is no rest and no end to intellectual contemplation, in this world or the next. The intellect is always active, and that activity is itself its rest. In Olam HaBa the righteous sit with crowns on their heads **ונהנים מזיו השכינה בעיון השכלי**, enjoying the radiance of the Shechinah through intellectual contemplation. "I think this could be written by the Rambam 100%."

Chapter 10, the Last Two Questions: Reward and Free Will

If people serve in Olam HaBa, what is their reward if they serve, and what happens if they do not? "Meaning, you've got complete free will whether you want to serve Hashem in Olam HaBa. I'm sitting there in Gan Eden and I decide I don't want to serve Hashem anymore."

Saadia says he answered this already: the Creator gives these commands only to those **He knows will choose to serve and not to rebel**. And when they choose to serve, He adds to their good. Since these two questions go back to earlier answers, his list counts as "ten" questions.

So, "believe it or not," there is free will to serve in Olam HaBa, but Hashem will only place in Gan Eden those He knows will serve, and they will be rewarded further for it. The Rabbi compared it to Saadia's answer, studied about two years earlier, to the question of human free will and Hashem's foreknowledge: we have free will, but Hashem knows what we will choose.

"And what happens if I worked really hard in this world, and Hashem knows I'm not going to serve in the next world? What happens to me then? I just find this so perplexing."

This is not about the days of Mashiach: the Rambam allows free will in Messianic times and perhaps at techiyat hametim. Saadia is speaking of Olam HaBa itself.

Flora's question

Why should service in this world imply service in the next? The Rabbi agreed one need not accept it. In this world we face "not a test, a kind of challenge. We finished our challenge and now we reap the consequences of the choices which we made." Flora added that the righteous sit with crowns on their heads and bask in the glory of Hashem; at most there is Torah and continuing to progress higher in spirituality. "That's precisely what the Maharsha said, and the Ben Ish Chai to some extent." The more you understand HaKadosh Baruch Hu, the more you bask in the radiance of the Shechinah. "But not that I've got free will to choose or not to choose to serve Hashem. That's a completely different concept. I don't know any other Rishon or Acharon who says what he says."

Chapter 11: Why We Are Not Told the Details

Saadia closes the essay by asking why we have only vague concepts of light and heat, and no detail of the exact reward for each mitzvah and the exact punishment for each sin. It was not defined in this world, for several reasons:

1. **We have not seen even the root.** We know the general concept of reward and punishment only by deduction, not experience. How could we grasp its finer branches?
2. **It would be too much.** The words of the Torah would become burdensome.
3. **We would pick and choose.** If we knew the reward of each mitzvah, we would choose the ones with the bigger reward and neglect the rest. As the Mishnah says:

הוי זהיר במצוה קלה כבחמורה, שאין אתה יודע מתן שכרן של מצות (Avot 2:1)

Be as careful with a light mitzvah as with a weighty one, for you do not know the reward of the mitzvot.

1. **We focus on what is near.** Our hearts are most occupied with what is coming next, the **salvation**. Before Olam HaBa, for Saadia, come Mashiach and techiyat hametim in this world, so the Prophets spent far more time on those than on Olam HaBa.

Saadia's hope

אני מקוה שיפרשו לנו בימות מלך המשיח גמול כל עבודה ועונש כל עבירה

I hope that in the days of the King Mashiach they will explain to us the reward of every service and the punishment of every sin.

At that time hearts will turn to seek wisdom and be refined to receive understanding, because they will be close to the time of Olam HaBa. That is why prophecy then will include everyone:

והיה אחרי כן אשפוך את רוחי על כל בשר (Yoel 3:1)

After this I will pour out My spirit on all flesh.

They will prophesy not only about past and future but about reward and punishment, and Hashem will give signs to confirm it: **ונתתי מופתים בשמים ובארץ** (Yoel 3:3). These things will come before techiyat hametim: **השמש יהפך לחשך והירח לדם לפני בוא יום ה' הגדול והנורא** (Yoel 3:4).

The final words of the essay

Whoever cares for his soul will be among the wise, and whoever guides others will be among those who bring the many to righteousness:

והמשכלים יזהרו כזהר הרקיע ומצדיקי הרבים ככוכבים לעולם ועד (Daniel 12:3)

The wise will shine like the radiance of the firmament, and those who bring the many to righteousness like the stars, forever and ever.

So every wise person should be vigilant and teach people the right way: teach your children, teach others, and spread the word of HaKadosh Baruch Hu.

Looking Ahead

That completes Essay 9. "As you can see, Saadia has a very physical understanding of Olam HaBa." The Rabbi planned to open the next shiur with a reflection on the whole essay, after the Tuesday shiur on the Rambam's conception of Olam HaBa.

Then **Essay 10**, which follows the end of Saadia's philosophical book. It is "more mussar, more of an ethical work," with short chapters, not all of it relevant, so the class would go through it quickly, finish the book, and begin something new in January or February.

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